

Video content improvements brief - April 2026

Project overview

The University of London delivers a significant proportion of its teaching through distance learning, often without the benefit of a physical campus experience. As such, video content plays a critical role in helping prospective students understand the University, its programmes, and the student experience.

The SCM Department is increasing the volume and variety of video content produced across its channels. This includes a greater emphasis on short-form and vertical video (for example, YouTube Shorts), as well as long-form and testimonial content.

Additionally, there is a planned increase in user-generated video content captured from students and stakeholders at events, graduations, and other touchpoints. A platform currently being assessed for this purpose is [eccho.video](#), and a set of video brand guidelines are being developed to support more consistent video production across the University.

While video production is expanding, the University's website currently presents limitations in how video content is surfaced, displayed, and optimised. This project seeks to review and improve how video content is presented across the University of London Drupal CMS websites, ensuring that video can be used more flexibly, performs well across devices, and is optimised for discoverability, including emerging AI-driven search experiences (GEO).

Problem to solve

The volume and formats of video being produced by the University are increasing, particularly short-form and vertical content. Without improvements to how video is presented and structured on the website, there is a risk that this content will be underutilised, inconsistently displayed, and poorly surfaced in both traditional search and emerging AI-driven discovery mechanisms.

This project will ensure the website is capable of supporting current and future video formats in a scalable, performance-conscious, and editor-friendly way.

Background and context

The University's website currently has several video-related slices and content opportunities, each with limitations:

- **Gallery slice** – Videos can be included but it is not immediately clear to users that the content is a video.
- **Media slice** – Video content displays in-page with a caption; this is the most straightforward implementation.
- **Testimonial slice** – Generally requires three videos to display optimally. The middle video can be a YouTube Short, but it is currently embedded in a non-vertical manner. Single-video display uses a two-column format; two videos display in three columns. Video opens in a modal, but users cannot swipe left or right to navigate between videos.
- **In-content video** – Videos can be added within content and play in-page.
- **Feature grid slice** – Videos open in a modal when added to this slice.

Heatmap data for course pages indicates that video engagement in hero positions is extremely low or non-existent. This informs the review of hero video placements as part of this project.

Objectives and success criteria

- Provide greater flexibility in how video content can be embedded and displayed across the website.
- Improve the visibility of video content and increase meaningful engagement.
- Ensure video content is structured and described to maximise eligibility for SEO and AI-generated search experiences (GEO).
- Natively support both horizontal and vertical video formats for a mobile-first approach across all relevant content types and slices.
- Review the use of video in hero placements and recommend alternatives based on performance insights, particularly on course pages.
- No negative impact on site performance or accessibility.

Scope and requirements

CMS functionality

To ensure video content can be managed, reused, and surfaced consistently across the Drupal CMS in a scalable and editor-friendly way.

- Improved video content surfacing opportunities across all University of London Drupal CMS theme sites.
- Ability to highlight a single video or showcase multiple videos on a page, expanding on current video-related slices: Media (with improved titles and captions), Testimonials (single or multiple formats, reduce need to scroll or display as a grid), Gallery (alongside photography).

- Ability to create dedicated video pages to group together related videos (e.g. all testimonial videos related to a specific degree), with associated filtering (e.g. RTC students / online students), for cases where there are more videos than can optimally be presented alongside core content.
- Expanded functionality to provide an optional thumbnail override image for a video (e.g. where a YouTube video does not include a customised thumbnail, or where text on the thumbnail would not be accessible when imported into the website).
- Ensure the Media module supports expanded and consistent metadata (e.g. titles, descriptions, tags, transcripts) to support SEO and GEO.

UX

To improve engagement and usability by presenting video content in ways that are intuitive, accessible, and appropriate to both desktop and mobile users.

- Opportunities to better display vertical video formats (e.g. YouTube Shorts) within the current site design and slices. Reference example: [Brown University vertical video usage guide](#).
- Optimised and consistent video display across desktop and mobile devices, including in-page playback and/or via modals where appropriate.
- Adherence to usability and accessibility best practices.
- Where videos open in a modal: clear visual cues indicating video content, and the ability for users to scroll or swipe left/right to view other videos within the same set.
- Review the positive or negative impact of placing course videos in hero positions, informed by existing heatmap data indicating very low interaction.

SEO / GEO

To ensure video content is structured, described, and contextualised in a way that maximises its eligibility for discovery via both traditional search engines and AI-generated search experiences.

- Application of video-related structured data (e.g. VideoObject) and adherence to Google Video Indexing requirements, where applicable.
- Ability to add and associate transcripts with video content, with guidance on when transcripts are recommended for accessibility and GEO optimisation, including an appropriate frontend presentation that adheres to best practice.

Performance

To ensure the increased use of video does not negatively affect page load times, site performance, or overall user experience.

- Optimised video loading approaches (e.g. lazy loading) to ensure video content does not negatively impact site performance.

Expected deliverables

- Updated or new video-related CMS components.
- Design guidance for horizontal and vertical video use.
- Technical implementation within Drupal.
- SEO/GEO and structured data implementation.
- Editorial guidance for CMS users.
- No negative impact on site performance or accessibility.

Users and audiences

- Prospective students researching University of London programmes via the website.
- CMS editors and content producers within the SCM Department who will manage and publish video content.
- Students and stakeholders generating user-created video content at events and graduations.

Reference URLs

- [eccho.video – user-generated video platform being assessed](#)
- [Brown University vertical video usage guide – reference for vertical video display](#)

Technical context

The University of London website is built on Drupal CMS and operates as a multisite setup across a number of theme sites. The work should be implemented within this Drupal environment and must integrate with the existing Media module. There are no specific third-party integrations beyond YouTube video embedding, though the platform eccho.video is being assessed for future user-generated content.

Design and brand

Video brand guidelines are currently being developed by the University to support more consistent video production across channels. These should be factored into any design guidance produced as part of this project. The work should sit within the University of London's existing design system and visual identity.

Content

Video content will be provided by the University. The SCM Department manages video production, with an increasing volume of content coming from short-form, testimonial, and user-generated sources. Editorial guidance will need to be produced as a deliverable to support CMS editors in managing and publishing video effectively.

Timeline and deadlines

- Solutions to be delivered and launched by end of July 2026.
- Invoicing in three stages: May, June, and July 2026.
- A prioritised approach within budget is expected, identifying any desirable enhancements that fall outside the available budget for consideration in a future phase.

Budget

Total available budget of £12,500 (inc. VAT) for recommendations, design, and build.

Stakeholders and approvals

Role	Name	Email
Project sponsor	James Moore	
Day-to-day contact	James Moore	
Technical contact	James Moore	
Final sign-off	James Moore	

Dependencies and risks

- The video brand guidelines are still in development; finalised guidelines may affect design recommendations.
- The eccho.video platform is under assessment; any integration work would likely fall outside this phase of budget.
- Heatmap data for course pages is referenced as an input; availability and recency of this data should be confirmed.

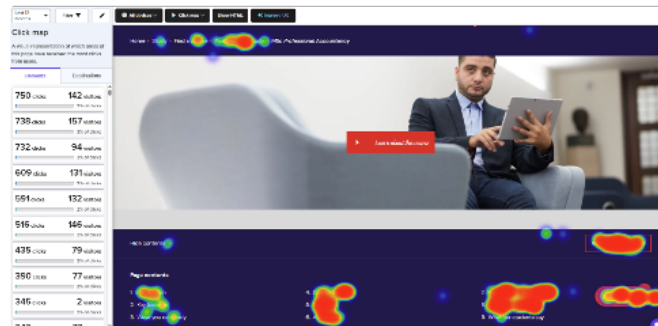
Supporting materials

- Course page heatmap data (referenced in brief, to be shared by University of London).
- Video brand guidelines (in development, to be shared when available).

Appendix

Course page heatmap

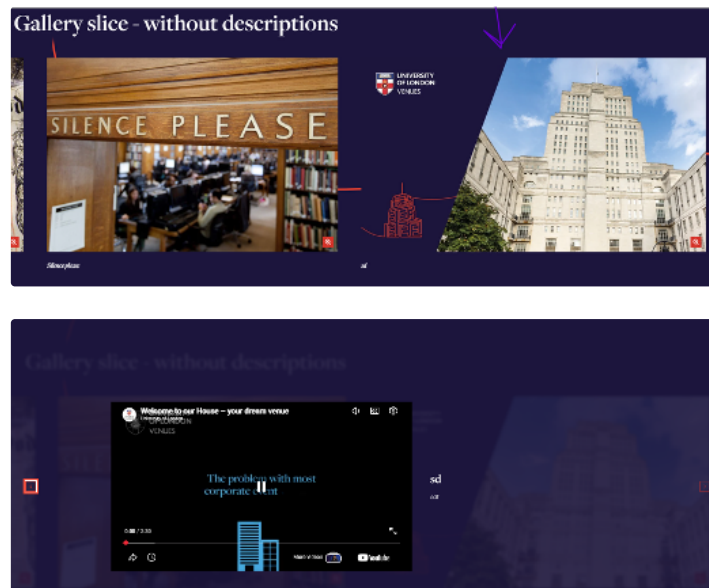
Indications are that video engagement in hero is extremely low/non-existent.



Current video content opportunities on the website

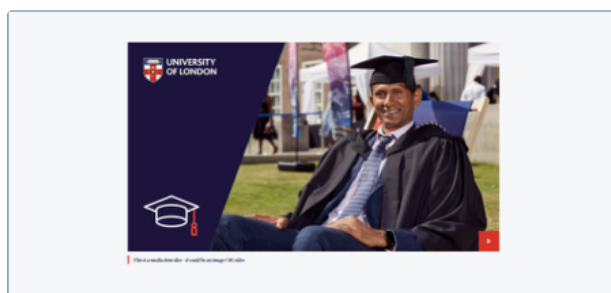
Gallery slice

It is possible to include a video in the Gallery slice, which display the video in a modal but it's not immediately clear this is a video.



Media slice

This is the current media slice, with caption. Video content displays in-page.

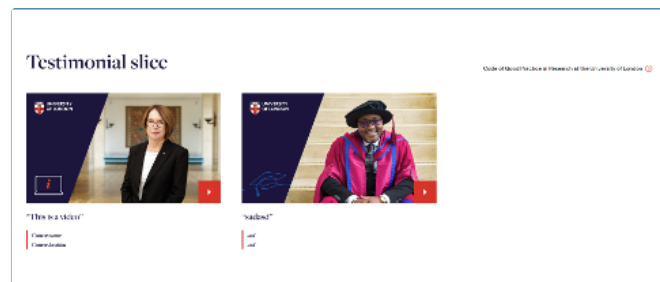
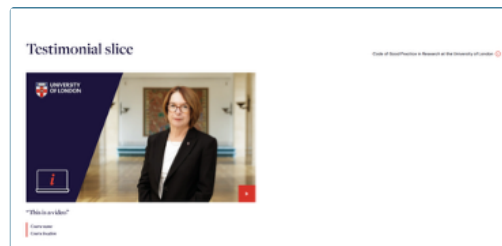


Testimonial slice

This slice generally relies on 3 videos to display optimally. The middle video is a YouTube short, embedded in a non-vertical manner.



When this slice is used with just one video, it display in a 2 column type of format, but when using two video it display in 3 column format.



Video content is then displayed in a modal (not possible to swipe left/right to see other videos in the “set”)



In-content video

Videos can be added within content and plays in-page.



Feature grid slice

When adding a video to this slice, it displays in a modal.

